Just a Memory (Don’t You Dare Forget Me)

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Teen And Up Audiences

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra) - mentioned

Additional Tags:
Inspired by Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind, Hurt/Comfort, Angst with a Happy Ending, Post-Break Up, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Don't Need to Know the Movie to Read, no beta we die like men, Clueless Lesbians in Love, They All Have Stupid Last Names, Non-Linear Narrative, It’s kinda like S3:Ep5 if ya wanna give it a try, Remember is a tough episode

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by roseswilsons

Summary

“I’m serious. I don’t want you to go.”

“I won’t,” she promised as she picked up Adora’s hand and left a reassuring feather light kiss across her palm. Maybe she’d still remember her after all.

Alternately: Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind AU where Catra forgets Adora so Adora does the only logical thing she can do - forget her back.

Notes

This idea came to me at 2am one night and I just had to write it because it love pain. A purely self-indulgent fic because I want it. You don't need to have seen the movie to understand it (at least I tried to make it that way).

If you wanna talk to me about it!
Twitter: roseswilsons
Tumblr: kevienday

i.

Adora woke that morning to the sun shining in her face and the taste of regret sitting on her tongue. She couldn't place where that feeling was coming from. Her brain felt clouded, and as she looked around her little studio apartment, nothing seemed out of the ordinary except that it seemed a little devoid of life. Huh, she usually liked to decorate. She'd get around to it eventually.

She reached for her phone, noting how early it was. No wonder she still felt exhausted and fuzzy. It's rare for her to get more than 5 hours of sleep at a time so she probably went to bed late last night. She scrolled through her phone until she landed on Glimmer's contact and hit call.

"…Adora?" Glimmer sounded sleepy, her voice thick from disuse. Shit, she had probably woken her up.

Adora cleared her throat. "Hey, Glimmer. I'm not feeling great today, is it okay if I don't come into work?"

A soft *oh, right* sounded from the other side of the phone. They sat in silence for a few moments and Adora was unsure as to why. She had called out of work a few times before. Today was nothing special. "Glimmer?"

"Oh, Adora, yeah of course you can," she rushed out. A rustle came from her end of the line as she moved about her bed. "How are you feeling?"

She grimaced. "I'm fine. My head just hurts a bit. Might have a migraine."

"Yeah, it'll do that. Take the time you need today." Glimmer was acting off today, like she was stepping on glass with each word that spilled out of her mouth. She decided not to acknowledge her friend's behavior, excusing it for being woken up so early.

“Thanks. I’ll talk to you later.” Adora stared at her surprisingly bare apartment, head still up in the clouds. She was ready to fall back asleep.

Glimmer sighed. “Talk to you later. Take care, Adora.”

Adora hung up before their conversation could find a way to continue. She felt bad for partially lying to Glimmer. Yes, her head hurt but it wasn’t a migraine. It felt jarring and empty like there was something she was forgetting or missing. Despite not knowing what it was, she just wanted to take the day to figure things out.

She carried on business as usual, forgoing her desire to fall back asleep. Maybe coffee would help her tired mind. She dressed quickly and left her sad apartment despite the bone-deep sluggishness that made her feel like she was constantly wading through water.

The café Adora went to was only a block away from her apartment; it was perfect for her slight coffee addiction. She usually went there with her friends, Bow and Glimmer, and sometimes Scorpia but it had been awhile since she had joined any of the best friends squad’s adventures to the café. Maybe Scorpia was busy with work, but she couldn’t remember the last time they had talked. Adora made a mental note to text her later.

Bright Moon Café was a stark pink against the beige colored walls of its neighboring businesses. The owner, Perfuma, decorated the café in wall to wall plants. She had such a large green thumb that Adora envied her ability to take care of plants. Once she had bought a cactus, one of the hardest plants to kill, and it still somehow ended up drier than the desert and thrown into her trash before a month had passed. Bright Moon was a cozy nook that usually harbored regulars so Adora knew she would be surrounded by familiar faces. Despite its popularity, the inside of the café was rather small with tables lined along the edges of the room surrounding the coffee counter in the middle.

She pushed her way inside and almost recoiled at how crowded the café was. It was packed, almost every seat filled with people, and a stressed out Perfuma manning both the cash register and coffee machine. Luckily, the large line passed quickly.

Adora idly chatted with Perfuma as she paid and waited for the bubbly blonde to make her drink. She scanned the area for somewhere, anywhere to sit. Usually she'd just go home if the café was packed, but for some reason today she didn't want to. Suddenly, her eyes flitted to a brunette sitting in the corner of the café alone on her laptop.

Perfect.

She thanked Perfuma and made her way over to the woman. There was something about her that seemed so familiar and inviting Adora couldn't help herself.

"Hi, do you mind if I sit there?" she asked, nervously rolling on her feet. "The café is crowded today."

The brunette looked up from her laptop startled, her heterochromatic eyes widened in surprise. She looked Adora up and down, her shocked face slowly morphing into one of confusion and slight annoyance. "Oh, uh, hi. Didn't I just see you the other day?"

Adora furrowed her brows and took a sip of her coffee. "No, not that I can remember."

"Huh, okay," the woman mumbled, more to herself.

"So, can I sit there? I get if you don't want a total stranger sitting with you," she stumbled over her words. "I can go."

"No," the brunette shook her head and moved her stuff slightly out of the way. "Go ahead."

Gratefully, Adora took a seat across from the woman. She smiled and held out her hand. "Thanks. I'm Adora, by the way."

The woman's tan hand grabbed hers briefly and gave it a firm shake. "Catra."

"It's nice to meet you, Catra."

ii.

It was no secret that their relationship was falling apart. They had been trouble for months. Despite knowing Catra since they were five years old, Adora felt like she knew nothing at all. Secrets upon secrets had piled up between them and only got worse as they officially became a couple. Whatever made them work in the beginning was no longer there and had left them in a non-communicative relationship.

In the beginning, everything seemed absolutely perfect. Same college, same friends, still together – it was everything they had dreamed when they were kids. But she had been looking through rose-colored glass to mask the steadily growing cracks in their relationship.

One fight became two and then every conversation they had somehow turned into a fight.

Adora didn't know how to fix it. She was supposed to be the one to keep everyone together, to keep *them* together, but she had failed even at that. It was a blow to her pride. She missed Catra so much. She regretted the moment she left Catra in their apartment after that last fight. It had been a mistake that had cost her everything.

Adora never meant to leave her girlfriend, her best friend. But she did and there was no going back.

She hadn't seen Catra in weeks. The woman seemed to be avoiding all their usual haunts. Adora missed having her in bed right next to her, just staring at the ceiling, talking like they were the only two people in the world. It was miserable. Adora was miserable and no one would tell her

what Catra was doing. She just wanted to make sure she was okay.

A month passed before Adora saw Catra walking along the street without a care in the world. She looked the same as before minus her hair. What was once a fluffy main of untamable hair was now cut short into a style that barely curled around her ears. It was just a reminder that they were no longer as inseparable as she once thought. As soon as she saw her, Adora broke out into a run.

"Catra!" she yelled. The woman seemed startled and stared with wide eyes as Adora barreled straight into her and gripped her biceps. "Catra, where have you been?"

"I'm sorry, who are you?" She asked as she wriggled her way out of Adora's grip.

Adora rolled her eyes. "Ha very funny, Catra. We need to talk. I know I was an ass, but I've been meaning to apologize. You don't have to pretend you've never met me before."

Catra hesitated and tensed as she stared at Adora. "But I've never met you before. Have you taken my order before or something? I'm sorry."

Adora took a step back. Catra, her best friend, had no memory of Adora and their times together. "Are you serious?" The woman in question shrugged and stared at the blonde. "You're serious. What the hell, Catra?"

"Listen, I've never met you before," she said, annoyed. Catra shouldered her way past Adora. "I'm sorry I'm not your friend, but I have to go to work."

Without another word, Catra took off down the street leaving Adora in shock. Her mind raced with so many different possibilities but only one scenario stuck with her. Lacuna.

Her distress led her to Bow and Glimmer's apartment later that day. She stormed up to their front door and knocked intently, her fist banged against the door in a quick succession of three. As soon as Glimmer opened the door to greet her, Adora stormed inside and looked for Bow. Said man was sitting comfortably on their couch reading what seemed to be one of the books his fathers had probably given him on a holiday or his birthday.

She planted herself firmly in his direct line of sight and spoke, her voice full of malice. "Did you know?"

Bow looked up from his book in confusion. He looked at Glimmer and her worried expression before he turned back to face Adora's unknown wrath. "What, Adora?"

"Did you know that Catra doesn't remember me?" she asked. "Why doesn't she remember me?" She was pleading, almost desperate to know the truth.

"Oh," he said softly.

"So, you do know!" she exclaimed. Addressing them both, she continued, "Glimmer, Bow, you guys have to tell me. I saw Catra on the street and she stared at me like I was a stranger. I've known her since I was five years old and we are definitely not strangers!"

They shared a nervous look, seeming to have a whole silent conversation before they both turned to Adora. "Okay. You should sit down."

Adora was brimming with anxiety. Her body was too wound up to properly function now let alone sit and calmly chat about their lives like they had all the time in the world and Catra still knew who she was. No, that was not their current scenario. She was freaking out and she needed answers *now* .

"I'm not gonna sit down!" Adora was all but yelling now.

The two sighed.

"Fine. Just don't freak out," Glimmer said as she turned and began to rummage through her purse. Adora knew her purse was a nightmare so whatever she was looking for was most likely lost to the ether, never to be found again- at least until Glimmer let out a noise of triumph and extracted a small envelope from her purse successfully.

As Glimmer walked back across their apartment, she paused just outside of Adora's reach and her embarrassing attempts at grabby hands. She looked down at the piece of paper like it contained all the secrets to the universe. The idea made Adora internally laugh. Whatever they thought they had to protect her from was probably nothing, they just like to overreact.

Adora made another attempt to swipe the paper from Glimmer's hands before the girl stopped her once more.

Bow called at them from his spot on the couch. "You have to promise!"

Adora sighed in frustration and rolled her eyes at their antics. "I promise, Bow. Just tell me what's up."

Hesitant, Glimmer handed her the small envelope. "Here."

Adora quickly opened the envelope to find a small slip of paper inside with a note neatly typed across it. Her curiosity quickly turned into worry.

Dear Ms.Brightmoon ,

Catrina Weaver *has had* ***Adora Grayskull*** *erased from her memory. Please never mention their relationship to her ever again.*

Lacuna Inc.

"Lacuna?" she laughed. A bubble of disbelief began to build up in her throat. This wasn't true. "Isn't that the weird lab you work at, Bow?"

He nodded and gave Adora a look of what could only be described as pity. “Yeah, I saw Catra there the other day. I’m so sorry I didn’t tell you Adora. It’s not like I could’ve stopped her.”

She froze in shock. “She just… erased me? Like that?”

“I’m sorry.”

This wasn’t right. They weren’t meant to end up like this, going through life like they never even met in the first place. “She wouldn’t do that. Catra wouldn’t want to forget me.” At their silence she hesitated, her mind racing. Adora let out an incredulous laugh. “Right?”

“I- I don’t know.” Glimmer reached toward Adora, her hand ready to grasp the other girl’s in comfort. Adora flinched from her before she could stop herself and Glimmer hesitated, her hand frozen halfway to its mark.

The room was closing in. Their usually spacious apartment was growing smaller and smaller, their walls collapsing in on themselves. Or maybe it was her own walls collapsing but it didn’t matter. Adora was freaking out and nothing they said could keep her here any longer. She stepped away from her friends who watched her in concern. “I can’t be here right now. I have to go. I can’t.”

Bow jumped up from his spot on the couch. “Adora, stop!”

She shook her head and took another step toward the door. “No.”

“Adora! Think rationally,” Glimmer said desperately. "It’s gonna be okay, you just gotta calm down. You don’t wanna do anything you’ll regret.”

Another step. She was closer to escaping their pitying gazes and suffocating words.

“I won’t.” She was thinking rationally. They just didn’t understand what this meant for her. What Catra did was unforgivable unless

she forgot it too. Another step.

They both stepped closer to her. They were too close. "You have to promise us that. You have to promise *me* that."

"I can't do that," she rushed. "I'll see you guys later."

She took off out of their apartment without a second thought and didn't even bother to shut the door on her way out.

iv.

A week had passed before Adora decided to get off her ass and deal with her emotions in the only way that made sense. The moment Adora walked into Lacuna Inc she steadfastly avoided Bow's pleading eyes. Her heart was in tatters, scattered across the room. There was no mistaking the feeling for anything other than heartbreak. If Catra wanted to forget her that was fine because she was going to forget as well. Nothing her friends could say or do would change her mind.

She sat in the uncomfortable waiting room chair and looked over the papers Bow had begrudgingly given to her. His soft eyes stared into hers as she took the forms from him; they pleaded for her to consider some other way to go about this.

"Just fill those out while you wait," he said sadly. "The doctor will come get you soon."

With the clipboard precariously balanced on her knees, Adora read through the company's legal statements and accountability for this procedure. Basically, the papers explained that Lacuna was not to blame, and this decision was 100% her choice and no one else's. It was like going to any other doctor's office and it soothed her to go through the stack of papers to fill out all her medical information. She was meticulous, neat, and got lost in the silence of the room until the click of a door snapped her out of her thoughts.

"Ms. Grayskull?"

She followed the doctor to the exam room and attempted to make herself comfortable on the thin sheet of plastic protecting her from every other patient that had sat on the bed prior to her. With every shift of her weight the bed crinkled with vigor, the sound drowning out the other sounds of the world. She began to pick at her nail beds anxiously, a habit she thought she had quit. Usually Catra was there to hold her hands and stop her. But this time she wasn't. That's why she was here.

The doctor fumbled with a small video camera for a minute or two before he turned and addressed her. "Hello Ms. Grayskull, it's nice to see you. I just wanted to check and make sure that you are aware of how this works. I'll be recording our session as a visual log for my personal records."

She swallowed the lump in her throat and tried to avoid picking further at her nails. "That's fine."

"When we spoke over the phone you said you wanted to forget Ms. Weaver, is that correct?" he asked. A beep emitted from the small camera he held signaling that he was now recording their conversation.

"Yes."

"Why don't you tell me about her," the doctor prompted.

She frowned. "I don't see how that's important."

"We'd like to know the reason why you want to forget," he explained carefully. "It's important for the big picture of the procedure."

Adora nodded and took a breath. As she spoke. She avoided looking directly at the camera, instead she focused on a textured patch of wall behind it.

"I'm Adora Grayskull and the main reason I'm doing this is because Catra did this first. She forgot me; she forgot our life together. And yes, I'm bitter. I'm angry. Why does she deserve to

forget everything that happened between us? We've known each other since we were kids, you know. There's a lot of history between us that I can't deal with alone."

The lump she had previously gotten rid of came back in full force, clogging her throat to signal she was done talking about this topic. However, the doctor prompted her to continue and she exhaled a shaky breath. It felt like her lungs were on fire, breathing rapidly with her anxiety, rushing to finish her story before it wrecked her completely.

She continued.

"I thought we were good together. I wanted to make it right. I said some stupid things the night she left, and I never got a chance to say that I'm sorry. I am sorry, but right now I feel like the best option for both of us is just to forget. I don't care anymore; it just hurts to think about her moving on."

The doctor said nothing but stopped the recording when Adora paused her speech. She sat on the patient's bench feeling like an empty shell of herself. He set his camera down and quickly jotted down a few things before he looked up at her.

"Now, I want you to go to your apartment and pack up any items that may have a connection to your relationship to Ms. Weaver or to Ms. Weaver herself and bring them back here during your next appointment."

"Why do I need that stuff?"

The doctor explained it calmly and carefully as if she was a spooked rabbit. "This procedure involves taking the objects from your lives together. We will use these to create a 'map' of sorts within your brain to find all the areas where Ms. Weaver resides. When you go to bed that night, we can use this map to erase her from your memories and in the morning, you won't remember her at all."

He acted as though this was a normal occurrence and not some life shattering event that was to take place. It felt like a death sentence. No more memories of Catra or their relationship. *That's fine,* she told herself. It had to be.

"Now, do you have any questions?"

Adora left her consultation feeling both raw and numb. She avoided Bow's stare on her way past the waiting room and as she stepped outside into the street, somehow her steps felt lighter like a weight had been lifted off her shoulders.

As she walked home, Adora noticed the leaves had begun to change again. Their once faded dull orange and brown now began to fall marking the approach of winter. She had been too wrapped up in her own misery she hadn't taken in her surroundings. The seasons changed with her relationship. Winter was snow, sleet, and frost. It was everything that life was incapable of surviving in. It brought along a cold death to the world and to her relationship.

Her apartment, what was once a vibrant place full of life now looked drab and grey in the reality of her new life. Her walls were covered in pictures of she and Catra looking happy and in love. It made her sick.

Adora grabbed the first bag she could find and began to rip pictures off the walls in such a fervor that caused a wave of pictures to fly all over the place. All these happy memories meant nothing anymore. Soon they wouldn't exist. She stared at the collage of their lives for a moment before stuffing it into her bag

The apartment contained little bits of Catra all around it. She didn't know how she didn't notice all those items sooner. A leather jacket draped across the kitchen chair. Melog's cat toys. A poster of one of Catra's favorite alt bands that had been hanging on their wall since their first year of college. The wooden sword of

protection Catra gave her as a gift from when they played their imaginary She-ra game. All these items once made her happy but now they just remind her of all she's lost.

The day of her procedure, the doctor and his assistant explained that they would use the items Adora brought in to stimulate her brain and create the 'map' of objects that connected her to Catra. That way they could erase all memories of her from Adora's brain overnight while she slept.

It was an odd procedure. The doctor had strapped a weird metal thing to her head that was used to map these memories. His assistant took the objects Adora gave them and showed them in front of her one by one, hoping to evoke feelings or reactions connected with each item. As they progressed, Adora realized this was probably for the better. There was no point in holding onto these memories if they person she was supposed to share them with didn't remember any of them.

When the procedure finished, the doctor sent her home with two small white pills and the instructions to take them before bed with a glass of water. Apparently, when she woke in the morning, she would be a new woman.

Adora felt the tiny pills weight in her pocket the whole way home. Their presence was an impending sense of doom. Once she took these, it was real. There would be no more of Catra and Adora, just Adora. When she got home, Adora immediately grabbed a glass of water and stared at the two tiny pills that would ensure her life to be forever changed. Before she could second guess herself, she placed the pills in her mouth and took a big gulp of water.

She shed her thick coat and stumbled over to her bed ready to get it over with. Maybe it was okay to forget.

v.

The first memory to make its way to the forefront of Adora's mind was their last as a couple, and the last time she had seen Catra before everything. It was a memory she didn't want to live through again. It reminded her of her failures.

The last dredges of sunlight were still making itself known through their open windows, refracting the sunlight in such a beautiful way. It bounced off Catra's annoyed face and made her glow like an angel. If they weren't having an argument, Adora would've told her that right then and there. Instead, her mouth repeated the words she constantly regretted.

"Catra, I can't stay. I have to go help them." Her hand was already on the doorknob. Why was her hand already on the doorknob? Was she that stupid?

Catra huffed an angry laugh and accidentally jostled an angry Melog in her arms. "No of course not. Just go like you always do."

"What?" Adora froze and faced her girlfriend.

"If you didn't want to be here then why are we together," Catra ground out, clearly trying to control her anger. Was that fear Adora saw in her eyes?

"Catra…" she spoke slowly, hoping to calm the girl. She took her hand off the doorknob and turned to face her girlfriend as she chose her next words carefully. "We're together because we love each other. Because *I* love you."

Her words only made Catra tense.

"But I'm always your second choice!" she exclaimed. "You choose everyone else over me."

Adora shook her head. "I do not."

"You're so self-sacrificing you don't even realize it. You deserve to be selfish. What do you want, Adora?" As Catra asked that

question her voice broke. It was a small question filled with so many answers, so many possibilities that left her at a standstill. Adora didn't know how to answer such a loaded thing.

She hesitated for a few seconds before she whispered "I- I just want everything to be okay."

"But do you want me, Adora?" Catra whispered, her voice almost nonexistent.

"Of course, I do. I love you, Catra, but our friends are having a crisis and I have to go help," she explained. Her words were meant to soothe not anger.

"No, you don't." Her voice was slowly becoming more brittle with each word she forced out of her mouth.

"Catra-"

Catra shook her head sadly before she steeled herself. Her grip on Adora's wrist loosened minutely as her body tended further.

"Adora, if you walk out that door, it's over. We're done. I'm seriously going to take Melog and leave. You have to be selfish for once!" She yelled and attempted to pull Adora closer to her in one last ditch effort to get her to stay.

Adora sighed. She knew she wasn't going to win this battle. They could talk about it after. "…I can't. I have to go, Catra. Please don't do anything until I get back."

She freed her wrist from Catra's loose grasp and watched her girlfriend's face crumple right in front of her eyes. She turned to grab the doorknob once again but didn't hesitate this time. Adora propelled herself out of their apartment before she could regret her actions. Adora didn't look back at the devastated look on Catra's face.

This was a good day. It wasn't particularly special, but it was perfect. If she could keep some snapshot of her life, it would be this one. It was a Saturday and for once they had no where to go, no one to meet, and nothing to do. All they did was sit around their apartment and listen to music. Adora was content to just sit and relax until a soft melody began to float across their apartment and inspiration struck.

"Hey, come here. Dance with me," Adora said, standing up from her previous position on the floor.

"Mmmm. I don't want to," she mumbled in response, snuggling deeper into their couch.

But Adora wouldn't take no for an answer. She stalked over to her girlfriend and grabbed the girls arm, giving them a light tug.

"Dance with me, Catra," she insisted, unwilling to let go.

Catra begrudgingly let herself be pulled up into a standing position.

"What are we five?" The girl grumbled as she let Adora pull them close. Despite her complaints Adora knew Catra could never say no to her wishes. If she wanted to dance, she's dance her heart out until they were both worn and content.

Adora flashed the girl her biggest puppy dog eyes and gave a small pout. "Please."

"Only because you asked so nicely," Catra said, giving Adora that beautifully crooked smile that always made her weak in the knees.

After a few minutes, Adora let her eyes slip shut as they swayed to the music together. Having Catra so close to her was comforting. Everything about the girl took her breath away. The music drifted lightly across their apartment as they danced, not quite with the music but at their own pace. When she opened her eyes she stood alone, swaying in the middle of her apartment.

She liked this song.

"Are you sure you want that one, Catra?" Adora asked hesitantly.

She was staring at a small scruff of a cat lovingly wrapped in Catra's arms. It didn't seem to mind being held by her but if anyone else got too close it immediately started hissing.

However, Adora knew she was a sucker for second chances and seemingly lost causes. This cat was definitely coming home with them.

It purred in her arms, eyes closed, and the girl seemed to do the same.

"Yes. He's perfect," Catra confirmed, holding the cat tighter.

Adora just started at the two. "He looks… angry."

"Not angry," she replied, shaking her head. "Just… prickly." The *like me* went unsaid but Adora could hear it in her voice.

And despite her better judgement, she agreed. "Okay, we'll get him."

She would always choose whatever she thought was best for Catra.

They stared at the wisp of a cat for another minute before one of the shelter's volunteers noticed they had stopped looking. The girl was too curious for her own good.

"Oh, you chose a cat?" she asked.

"Yes, we like Melog!" Catra said enthusiastically. She held the cat toward the girl like he was a prize at the county fair she had just won.

"Perfect, I'll get the paperwork."

As she walked away Adora got caught up staring at the other cats in the adoption clinic. They were all so cute she wished she could take them all. She forgot the reason she came to the clinic in the first place but she didn't mind. Being all alone in the room allowed her to clear her head and relax. As she stared at the cats she realized that she had a thing for strays.

She blinked and suddenly the girl from before was back. "Hi, ma'am, are you looking for a cat today?"

It was the first day of the rest of their lives. They were officially adults and in college. After all the shit she and Catra has gone through it was nice to have something to look forward to.

On their way up to their apartment, they had run into two other people, a boy and girl, who offered to grab the boxes Catra was struggling to keep balanced in her arms.

It was a short trip but it sucked their dorm had no elevator. When they got to the door of their new private space, Adora turned to the short, pink-haired curl and tall, muscular boy. An unlikely friendship but so was her friendship with Catra so she didn't judge.

"Hey, thanks for helping us move in! I'm Adora," she said breathlessly as she set down her own box to open the door.

"It was no problem," the girl exclaimed. "We are neighbors after all. I'm Glimmer."

"Nice to meet you!" Adora smiled and let them all into the bare dorm room.

The boy smiled and set down one of her heavier boxes on top of her desk. "Nice to meet you, too! You should come over soon. I don't want you to get lonely because you have a single dorm."

“I don’t have a single dorm,” she stated, confused. In the rush of it all, Adora hadn’t noticed Catra disappear from her sight.

“Huh, but that’s what it says on your door.” He walked over to the edge of her room and swung the door back so she could see its outside. The door was empty minus a small decal decorated white and gold with her name written neatly in the center.

She looked around the room and realized it only contained one of everything: one desk, one bed, one dresser.

“Oh, I must’ve been mistaken. I’ll stop by when I’m done unpacking.”

“Thanks for being here, Catra. I don’t know what I’d do without you,” she mumbled into the brunette’s side.

Catra let her grip tighten and squeezed Adora a little tighter. “I’d never leave you alone. Especially only a day like today.”

Today was the worst. It was dark, the clouds hanging down lower than usual as if they sensed the sadness that radiated from Adora’s form. The only warmth she received was that of Catra’s steady body leaning against hers in a sign of silent support.

Saying goodbye was never easy, especially when it comes from out of the blue.

Wreathes of flowers adorned Mara’s freshly dug grave. Their vibrant pinks, yellows, and whites were stark against the dark brown of the soil. Life against death. It was almost ironic.

Adora didn’t know how long she had been sitting there staring at her guardian’s grave. It didn’t matter if she was 7 or 17, she was gonna miss her like hell. She needed Mara in her life. A clap of thunder boomed in the distance signaling the beginnings of a storm.

She didn’t know where to go.

“Hi, honey,” Razz, Mara’s grandmother, rasped from behind. Adora, who was used to Razz's spooky antics, only peered at her through puffy eyes and attempted a smile. It was always hard to be sad around Razz.

“Do you need me to take you home? It’s getting dark,” she said. The old woman was blind as a bat and stumbled around with a cane everywhere she went but she was a surprisingly coherent driver.

“No that’s okay. Catra said I could come over to her house so I don’t have to be alone.”

Razz looked around the cemetery confused. “Who, dearie?”

“Cat-” she started to say before she noticed the absence of solid, grounding weight against her side. “Oh.”

Razz tutted and offered a shaky hand. “I can’t have you alone on such a day full of sorrow.”

“Thanks for being here, Razz,” she said sincerely. Adora grabbed Razz’s hand and dusted off her black dress that was now dirty from the fresh soul. She didn’t know how she was going to make it without Mara but at least she had a friend in Razz.

“Anytime, dearie. Now, I think it's the perfect day to go berry picking, don't you?”

Memories began to flood across her mind, dragging Adora through each, making her relive the good, the bad, and the bittersweet moments of her life with Catra. It was painful to watch such a huge part of her life disappear into the wind. As each memory passed, Adora became filled with more dread and anxiety. She had to stop it. She didn’t want to forget Catra, she couldn’t.

For once in her life, Adora acknowledged that she made the wrong decision.

vi.

"I'm losing you," Adora whispered into the quiet of their shared apartment, worried that Catra didn't hear her. Of course she didn't, the girl was intensely focused on her laptop. However, her anxiety was quelled slightly when the other girl let out a bemused laugh, her eyes still reading over her hastily written essay.

"You aren't losing me. I'm right here, idiot." Catra gave her a pointed look at the last word to emphasize her thoughts.

She was being an idiot. A scared idiot worried of losing the only person she'd ever loved, but this version of Catra didn't know that. It was only a memory.

Adora chewed her lip and shifted anxiously in place on their couch. "I'm forgetting you. I made a mistake. I don't want to forget you."

The clear anxiety in her voice made Catra look up fully and turn to Adora. Her brows were pinched with worry as she looked at the blonde's tense posture and wrecked lips.

"I'm not going anywhere," Catra said as she made her way over to her. The couch groaned slightly with the added weight but she didn't mind as she slumped into the solid weight pressed against her. "We're going to stay right here until the day we die."

"I'm serious. I don't want you to go."

"I won't," she promised as she picked up Adora's hand and left a reassuring feather light kiss across her palm. Maybe she'd still remember her after all.

“What are you talking about Adora?” Catra asked, eyebrow raised as she calmly sipped her coffee. They were sitting at their usual tiny table in Bright Moon café as they did ever Friday afternoon after their classes had finished.

“I need to hide you.” Her own drink had gone cold beside her a long time ago as Adora fretted over what to do next.

Another confused glance. “Why?”

“They’re making me forget you,” she said, seriously. They were losing time and Catra needed to follow her right now.

“Who?”

“The people at Bow’s weird lab job,” Adora explained as if it was that simple.

“Why would they do that?” she asked, taking another sip of her coffee.

“Because I wanted them to.”

Catra’s eyebrows raised in shock at her admission. She knew exactly what Bow’s work did for people. Even in a memory she could never believe they would willingly forget each other. Life was great why change it? She didn’t respond to Adora’s remark and the two sat in silence and worry as the bustle of the coffee shop drowned out their own thoughts.

“Stop staring,” Catra grumbled, her mind still reeling from the truth.

Adora shook her head vigorously. “No. I don’t want to take my eyes off you. You’ll leave me faster.”

“I won’t leave you,” she laughed. “You know that, Adora.”

But Adora could feel her resolve begin to break and wobble. It would be soon. They would infest this memory and warp it to

what she thought she wanted. It was soon to be replaced with nothing. “You already are.”

Within the blink of her eye, it was like Catra hadn’t been there at all. Everything had disappeared except her coffee cup which was still warm to the touch.

Another memory flashed in her mind and suddenly it was snowing. Adora stared at a bundled up Catra in her usual leather jacket who seemed grumpy at the fact that they were laying outside in the freezing cold. It was dark and she was chilled to the bone but Adora remembered this night. Despite the snow covered ground, Adora had wrestled the other girl to the ground so they could look up at the stars. It didn’t take long for Catra to see Adora’s warmth and use said girl as a human heating pad.

Usually, with Catra almost purring into her side and the beautiful night sky in perfect view, Adora would be happy. Instead she was worried. Her hand caressed Catra’s thick hair softly to reassure herself that they were still there together.

“I can’t stop it. You’re going to be gone, Catra.” As she talked she could see her breath curling around their heads in long wisps. She focused on that and tried not to choke on her own emotion.

However, Catra being Catra knew how to deal with Adora and her anxieties a mile away. She glanced up from her spot on the blonde and gave her a reassuring smile. “Adora, calm down. We’re only moving to a new city. You’ll see me tomorrow.”

“Not that. You’re disappearing.” Her hand clenched tighter in Catra’s hair.

“I’m with you all the way, you fool. It’s the two of us together,” Catra said, her tone final.

“You promise?” Adora asked as she waved her hand in front of the brunette’s face, pinkie out.

“I promise,” Catra replied, her voice a quiet whisper. She interlinked their fingers in a silent promise to each other.

They sat in comfortable silence as they stared at the sky. She was so caught up in watching the clouds dance across the sky, she didn’t hear the approaching footsteps from behind.

“Adora, what are you doing out in the cold?” Glimmer’s voice called out of the dark. She peered her head and looked at Glimmer’s tense form.

“I’m admiring the stars one last time,” she sighed contently. It was peaceful in the park. “It always feels like they’re never there but tonight you can see them so clearly.”

“What? Adora, we can always see the stars. Let’s get inside, you’re gonna freeze your ass off,” Glimmer stated, holding out a hand for Adora to grab.

“Not always,” she mumbled and accepted her friend’s hand which felt like fire compared to her ice cold hand.

“Okay, Adora,” Catra said seriously, holding Adora’s face in her hands so the girl wouldn’t look anywhere else. “You have to hide me somewhere they can’t find me.”

This memory began as a trip to the coast to see the ocean one last time before they graduated from high school. It quickly devolved into a rushed explanation and Catra finally realized that this was the end. She had to hide for Adora’s sanity.

“There’s nowhere.” Adora felt defeated, her eyes wandered to the few other people that had stopped at the rest stop just off the highway. Luckily the two girls hadn’t left their car yet or she didn’t know what she’d do. Run, maybe. There was no way she could hide Catra, well, her memory, from the weird Lacuna people. “They have a whole map of my brain, my memories.”

“But you said that they take this map of items you gave them and use that to erase me. Let’s just find a spot they won’t be able to go to,” Catra whined.

“Where?”

She squeezed Adora’s face and pulled her closer so their foreheads were touching. “Think about someplace without me. A place you made memories that didn’t ever involve me.”

Adora shut her eyes as she willed away the fresh tears that were threatening to fall down her face. “I want to stay with you Catra but you don’t remember out there in the real world. This already happened.”

It was comforting to have her girlfriend in such close proximity again. She missed them together as a unit. They fit together like two pieces of a puzzle and without her she was lost. Even in her memories Catra remained as perfect as always.

“You have to remember. For *us* . And when you see me in the real world and remember our relationship, you can explain,” she explained it like it was an easy thing to do. Convincing real life Catra would be a task and a half. She’d never go for it unless she had hard proof that they even knew each other.

“That’s never going to work,” she said. Her body was starting to cramp from being pulled over her car’s center console but she didn’t want to pull away from her girlfriend’s touch. “You’re already disappearing.”

“Then think, Adora. Use your head. You have to hide me.”

She nodded and screwed her eyes shut. She imagined a place she has only ever told Catra about in secret underneath the covers. “Okay.”

It was a place she’d rather never visit again but if it meant she could preserve some memory of her best friend, she would relive it a hundred times.

The scenery warped around them and when she opened her eyes Catra was much younger than she had ever seen her in person. She looked tiny and meek compared to the strong confident woman she had known almost all her life.

“Where are we?” Catra asked.

Her room was bare and devoid of any life. Her ‘parents’ if she could even call them that had refused to let her decorate. They didn’t really let her do much of anything. It wasn’t great but she could’ve been treated worse.

“My first foster house,” she gasped. “Before I got adopted by Mara.”

Catra’s hands remained on her face as she
studied Adora’s features. If she moved her tongue around a bit she could feel the phantom movement of a wiggling baby tooth ready to pop out.

“You look so young.” She scrunched her face in disgust.

“I was,” Adora affirmed, her voice pitched higher than usual. She craned her head to try and hear any incoming footsteps from the rest of house but all she could hear was complete silence. Good. Catra didn’t need to know their nastiness. “You should be safe here; I hadn’t met you until after all of this.”

Catra frowned and stared at the obviously blank walls. “Doesn’t seem nice.”

“It wasn’t.”

“I wish I knew you-” she started, but it was too late. They had found her even in a place she had never been before.

“No, no, no!” Adora cried out before she was taken to another memory on the map.

In her memories, she and Catra kept getting younger. They were following her map all the way to the very end (or beginning) to when she first met the person she cared for most in the world. There she was slowly disappearing in front of Adora's eyes and she was powerless to stop it.

"I'm the mighty She-Ra! No one can stop me!" Adora yelled, wielding her wooden sword as she stood on top of one of the large rocks that decorated Mara's backyard.

"I can defeat you!" Catra replied. She ran and pounced on Adora knocking them both off the rock and into the dirt.

"No, you can't, Catra! She-ra beats all!" She complained, wrestling the other girl.

"That's not how it works, Adora." Catra has managed to hold her down to the ground and she sat on Adora's body in triumph. Smugly she said, "I can take you."

"Oh yeah? Let's go again. I have a sword," she said cockily.

As she was about to attempt to push Catra off her small friend, a familiar distant voice called out to her.

"Adora, honey?"

Adora looked away from the young version of Catra and stared at the woman who had basically raised her. It gave her goosebumps to see her after all those years without her. Still, she involuntarily responded. "Yeah, Mara?"

"Can you stop rolling around in the grass? You're gonna get your nice dress all dirty," she asked nicely.

She shrugged and stared down at the gold and white dress that adorned her body. It was perfect for her She-ra costume. Quickly, she picked herself up off the ground and ran toward her caretaker. "Okay, Mara!"

“Try and hide me again, Adora,” Catra spoke in a soft voice, unwilling to show her hopelessness just yet.

“I don’t know where.” She couldn't do this anymore. It was too late.

“Yes, you do," she tried again. "Think.”

But Catra was gone before she even had a chance to think. It was getting quicker now.

It was dark. Adora faced Catra under the covers of their bed. Said girl was the picture of content. She had fallen asleep a little while ago and her body finally relaxed into the mattress. Adora slowly moved her hand and pushed a piece of loose hair out of Catra’s resting face. These were the only instances in which Adora could watch Catra as herself without the usual guarded walls she put up throughout the day.

“I’m going to miss you,” she whispered into the dark like it was a secret.

Catra sighed and mumbled back. “I’m right here. I’m not going anywhere.”

“I love you.”

Catra grabbed Adora’s waist and pulled her close so they were flush against each other. “Love you too, ‘Dora. Now go to sleep.”

Her memories were getting hazy. She couldn’t stop them from taking Catra away and it was all her fault.

She hid her in the darkest parts of her mind. They were the places she had whispered to Catra about in the dark during one of their most vulnerable moments never to be uttered again outside of their little bubble. They were painful and sad, parts of her life she'd rather forget.

But she couldn't and that's why she grabbed Catra. Adora would take her to hell and back before she'd willingly give up the woman she loved.

Each attempt was a moot effort.

Catra hid with her under the table of one of her first foster homes while her foster mother went on a rampage. Gone.

Catra came with her to bake pies with Mara and Razz. These were moments that were special to Adora's heart but most importantly they were far thoughts from Catra. It was only a few minutes before the girl was gone again.

Driving to the middle of nowhere. Gone.

Every place off the map she could think of led to the same tragic scenario of silence beside her.

Gone. That's all she was. Catra was no longer even a memory. She was a whisper in the wind, a vaguely familiar name. She was nothing but a stranger.

Before she knew it, they hit her last memory. The final piece of Catra her brain was still desperately clinging onto. The first time they met.

Adora and Catra sat side by side, their compact bodies hidden under the play structure as they talked. Both girls were a little beat up but otherwise content to be in each other's company. It was the day Adora vowed to take care of Catra, to never let her go.

But she let her down like she let everyone else down.

“Hey, we’re gonna stick together,” Adora said, facing the girl as she held out her pinkie. “It’ll be you and me against the world.”

Catra stared at Adora’s pinkie hesitantly like it would burn her. “Really? Do you promise?”

Adora nodded firmly and stuck her pinkie out further for the girl. “I promise. I’m never leaving you.”

Enthused, Catra stuck her own pinkie out and interlocked their fingers. A promise sealed between the two.

When they let go, Adora hid her face in her knees as she felt warm tears leak form her eyes. She didn’t have the guts to look up. Despite the loudness of the playground around her, there was an eerie silence that overwhelmed her sense. Adora didn’t have to look up to know Catra was gone. In a blink, she righted herself and brushed off the tears. She must’ve fallen off the playground.

Weird, she thought.

vii.

Adora and Catra fell into an easy conversation at the café, ignoring the bustle of the crowds and Perfuma’s odd looks. They were so comfortable with each other it was like they had known each other their whole lives. There was no awkwardness or odd stretches of silence. Learning about Catra and her life was the most interesting topic Adora ever listened to.

The girl paused their continuing conversation when a ‘ping’ emitted from her laptop. “Hold on, my email just went off. I have to check it just in case it’s work,” she said in a guilty voice.

Adora peered over at the girl’s laptop and noticed the sender with surprise.

“Lacuna?” Catra muttered, confused.

“Lacuna…” Adora hesitated. “My friend Bow works there.”

“You know Bow, too? That’s awesome!” Catra exclaimed, clearly excited to learn more information about the other. They had a lot of things in common; she guessed it was why they meshed together so easily.

She nodded and smiled. “Yeah! I can’t believe he’s never mentioned you before.”

“What do you think they want?” Catra asked, her attention once again focusing on the email pulled up on her laptop. It was odd to receive an email from a company she’d never reached out to in the first place.

Adora shrugged. “I’m not sure but there’s only one way to find out.”

She watched as Catra clicked her laptop a few times. Her excited stare turned confused as she looked at the email closer.

“Huh, it’s from Bow,” she said. “All it has is a note and a video attachment. That’s odd.”

“What does it say?” Adora asked. Unfortunately, it was in her nature to be nosy and she quickly withdrew her statement as she recoiled from her close proximity to Catra. “If you’re okay with telling me that is.”

Catra gave one glance to Adora and then back to her laptop. She shrugged and chewed her lip. “Why not?”

Quickly, she moved her chair closer to Catra so they sat side by side rather than across from each other. Now that she could see the girl’s laptop screen fully, she watched as Catra hovered over the message left by Bow.

“‘*Catra, I know we don’t speak much but I believe you’ve made a huge mistake. I know that you won’t remember anything from your lives together, but Catra, you need to understand I’m doing*

this for you and Adora . You loved her and you were happy together. I don't think you should ruin that.'"

"I- me?" She gaped like a fish. The two shared a glance. Something was going on more than they knew.

Hesitantly, Catra clicked on the video. Her own face popped into view and the video began to play automatically.

"Hello, my name is Catra Weaver and I am here to erase Adora Grayskull from my memories."

Catra was quick to pause the incredibly invasive video and avoided Adora's concerned eyes. They both sat frozen staring at the paused video of Catra's wrecked face talking about their apparent relationship. The girl next to her tensed further when she saw Adora shuffle uncomfortably in her seat. They sat in silence for a minute as though they were frozen in time while the rest of the world carried on as usual. Like their whole reality didn't just shatter in front of their very eyes.

Adora didn't know what to do. This woman was a complete stranger but apparently, they knew each other better than anyone else. For once in her life she didn't know what to do. Adora glanced between Catra and her recorded face. The woman had yet to say anything but Adora didn't want to be there when she tried.

With the grace of a newborn deer, Adora abruptly stood. "Umm, I'm gonna go. I think I should go. I can't be here."

Catra glanced up at Adora's frazzled form, her own face a perfect picture of apathy. She'd believe it too if she didn't know how to read the girl so well. Her body was tense as if she was waiting for someone to jump out and yell that it was a joke. She nodded and shut her laptop. "Yeah."

"Bye," she squeaked out and ran out the door and into the frigid almost-winter air without so much as a look back.

viii.

Adora's mind was racing. She flung open her apartment door and stared at the emptiness it created. She didn't know what to think. Today, Adora met one of the most amazing people she'd ever met before and suddenly, based on a video starring said girl, they already knew each other once upon a time.

A joke.

That was what it must be. A sick joke. Bow must've gotten this girl to play along in his little prank because there was no other explanation. Dread settled in her stomach as she fished out her phone only to find a text from Bow waiting for her.

> **Bow**
>
> Hey, Adora. I don't want you to freak out on me or anything but I need you to hear this.
>
> I couldn't stop you from erasing your memory but it was a mistake. You deserve love, you deserve Catra. I'm not supposed to do this but you need to know.
>
> Just check your email.

She pulled up the application on her phone and in bold glaring letters was the word Lacuna exactly like Catra's email. Shakily, she tapped the message and saw that it also had a video attachment. A lump began to climb up her throat. She felt like she was choking. This couldn't be real life. Clearly, she was still dreaming. Adora felt her legs give out from under her and she slumped against the wall for support.

Despite her better judgement, she clicked the attachment and was greeted with her own angry frown and tired eyes. Her voice began to flood her apartment and Adora choked out a sob. It was real.

"*I'm Adora Grayskull and the main reason I'm doing this is because Catra did this first. She forgot me; she forgot our life together. And yes, I'm bitter. I'm angry...*"

Adora let her eyes wander as she listened to herself in the video. She sounded so angry and broken. However low she had been was bad. But she still remembered. That girl had memories Adora could only hope to remember. And apparently, they all had to do with Catra and her influence.

A flash of color in her drab apartment caught her eye from below her chair. As she leaned over to grab the object, she realized it was a photo. Must've missed it when she collected all her things for the procedure. Her hands trembled as she stared at the photo. In it, she and Catra were smiling brightly, their bodies relaxed atop the same bed that Adora slept in every night, looking almost divine. That was their life before. Before she had to go and ruin it.

Adora sniffled, rubbing her eyes free of tears that had fallen in her daze as she tuned back into reality to listen to the last few seconds of her own devastating voice. "*...I don't care anymore; it just hurts to think about her moving on.*"

The silence of her apartment was deafening as she sat and stared. It was like her whole world got turned entirely upside down and everything she thought she knew was a lie. She couldn't trust her own memories anymore.

—-

She had spent the rest of her day reeling from shock. In her bed, she thought of all the odd occurrences from that day and all of them led to Catra. God, Catra. They knew each other so much more than they could ever know and they both chose to take that knowledge away.

The thought was sickening.

As she looked around her room she noticed areas she thought were bare from lack of decoration were most likely bare because part of Catra had been there. It hurt. A knock on her door cut through the silence. Adora didn't know how long it had been since she ran home but she figured it must be Glimmer or Bow checking up on her. She had no clue where her phone was.

She shuffled slowly over to the door and opened it expecting to see her overbearing best friends. Instead she was face to face with the woman she almost knew.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said hesitantly as she gave her a small wave. She looked as out of place as Adora felt.

"Catra, what are you doing here?" she asked.

The girl shuffled nervously in place, unsure. "I texted Bow. He assumed you'd come back here. I didn't mean to be creepy or anything." She paused her rushed explanation. They stared at each other for a minute in silence before Catra broke it with a small laugh. "Crazy, huh? We had a life together."

Adora attempted a reassuring smile that she was sure looked more like a grimace. Right now all she wanted was to collapse in on herself. How the hell was she supposed to deal with a situation like this. "Sounds like it could've been better."

"We seemed happy though, no?" Her question was filled to the brim with anxiety ready to explode.

"Yeah," she said, staring into those two-toned eyes that made her knees feel weak. "We did until the end, I guess."

Catra continued. "For the past few weeks, I've felt like I've been missing something in my life, like a piece of my puzzle suddenly went missing." Her words burst forward without a filter like a dad had broken inside her mind and she couldn't stop. "I think that piece was you, Adora."

Catra said her name so softly, softer than she had ever heard anyone say her name before. Her heart melted at the thought but she didn't want to drag this girl into another unhappy relationship.

Adora leaned against her doorway. "I don't wanna mess it up again."

"You won't."

"How can you be so sure?" she questioned. "I can't do anything right. It's just going to happen again."

"I believe in you," Catra insisted as she reached for Adora's hand. Despite her instinct, she let the brunette grasp her hand lightly. "And that people can change."

Catra intertwined their fingers and Adora knew whatever was left of her resolve had broken.

"Okay, fine. Let's try it again," she said as she squeezed Catra's hand. "For us."

"You promise?" The other girl asked. A knowing grin etched its way on to her face. Her lopsided smile a forgotten memory in Adora's mind – gone yet so familiar. She smiled back in return and pulled Catra into her apartment.

"I promise."

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